Real Time Foreign Object Intrusion Detection for No Fly Zones

21CSE292P-ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE OF THINGS

PROJECT REPORT

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in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

BACHELOR OF TECHNOLOGY
in
COMPUTER SCIENCE ENGINEERING



DEPARTMENT OF NETWORKING AND COMMUNICATIONS
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NOVEMB

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

We express my humble gratitude to **Dr. C. Muthamizhchelvan**, Vice-Chancellor, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, for the facilities extended for the project work and his continued support.

We extend my sincere thanks to Dean-CET, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, **Dr. Leenus Jesu Martin M**, for his invaluable support. We wish to thank **Dr. Revathi Venkataraman**, **Professor & Chairperson**, School of Computing, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, for her support throughout the project work.

We am incredibly grateful to our Head of the Department, **Dr. M. Lakshmi**, **Professor and Head**, Department of Networking and Communications, School of Computing, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, for her suggestions and encouragement at all the stages of the project work.

We register my immeasurable thanks to our Faculty Advisor**, Dr. M Kandan, Assistant Professor**, Department of Computing Technologies, School of Computing, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, for leading and helping us to complete our course.

Our inexpressible respect and thanks to our faculty, **Dr. Naga Malleswari T Y J, Associate Professor,** Department of Networking and Communications, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, for providing us with an opportunity to pursue our project under her mentorship. She provided us with the freedom and support to explore the research topics of our interest. Her passion for solving problems and making a difference in the world has always been inspiring.

We sincerely thank the Networking and Communications department staff and students, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, for their help during our project. Finally, I would like to thank parents, family members, and friends for their unconditional love, constant support, and encouragement.

The authors gratefully acknowledge the support of the Intel Unnati IoT Solutions Lab at SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST), Kattankulathur, for providing the necessary infrastructure, resources, and technical guidance that significantly contributed to the successful completion of this project work. The advanced facilities and collaborative environment at the lab enabled effective experimentation, data analysis, and validation of results, fostering innovation and excellence throughout the project.

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ABSTRACT

The increasing presence of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), drones, and other low-altitude flying objects has created growing challenges for modern surveillance and security systems. Unauthorized aerial intrusions can threaten critical infrastructures, compromise privacy, and disrupt restricted airspaces, especially around defense installations, airports, and government facilities. To address these challenges, this project presents a real-time No-Fly Zone Detection and Alert System that integrates computer vision, IoT communication, and physical actuation to detect, track, and alert against unauthorized airborne objects. The system employs a lightweight deep learning model trained on a custom dataset containing various aerial object classes. Through a continuous live camera feed, the model performs real-time detection and classification of flying objects entering the surveillance perimeter. When a foreign or unidentified object is detected, a servo-controlled rotating light is activated to track the object's trajectory, ensuring visual focus on the intruder. Alongside, a buzzer generates an immediate local alert, notifying nearby authorities or operators of a potential breach. To extend monitoring beyond local premises, the event data, including detection time, object type, and visual snapshots, is transmitted to an IoT dashboard. This allows remote users to observe incidents in real time, store historical records, and analyze intrusion trends for improved situational awareness. The entire system is optimized for edge deployment, processing data locally to minimize latency and maintain operation even in limited network environments. The proposed design prioritizes affordability, modularity, and scalability, making it suitable for a range of security applications from academic campuses and industrial zones to defense perimeters. Future upgrades may incorporate radar sensing, acoustic analysis, and RF signal tracking to strengthen detection reliability under complex environmental and weather conditions. Overall, the project demonstrates an effective, low-cost, and intelligent approach to safeguarding no-fly zones through real-time automated surveillance.

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ABBREVIATIONS

UAV Unmanned Aerial Vehicle

CUAV Counter-Unmanned Aerial Vehicle

ML Machine Learning

DL Deep Learning

CNN Convolutional Neural Network

YOLO You Only Look Once

SOTA State Of The Art

CV Computer Vision

IoU Intersection over Union

mAP mean Average Precision

FPS Frames Per Second

SoC System on a Chip

DNN Deep Neural Network

API Application Programming Interface

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

The evolution of aerial threats due to the proliferation of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) and drones has dramatically changed the landscape of airspace security. As critical infrastructure sites and no-fly zones face increasing vulnerability from unauthorized aerial intrusions, the need for robust, real-time detection systems has become a vital concern for both governments and private organizations. This report presents the development and evaluation of a comprehensive Real-Time Foreign Object Intrusion Detection system tailored for no-fly zones using advanced computer vision and AI techniques. The following chapter introduces the context, challenges, and objectives underlying this project.

1.1 Overview of Aerial Security Challenges

The rapid evolution and increasing accessibility of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) have fundamentally transformed modern society[1,2]. What began as a technology confined to military and research institutions has become democratized through consumer markets, now available to recreational enthusiasts, commercial enterprises, and unfortunately, malicious actors. While UAVs and drone technology have enabled revolutionary capabilities in sectors ranging from agriculture and infrastructure inspection to emergency response and logistics, this proliferation has simultaneously created unprecedented security vulnerabilities that traditional defense mechanisms were never designed to address.

Critical infrastructures representing the backbone of modern civilization—including airports, military installations, power plants, government facilities, research laboratories, and financial centers—now face growing threats from unauthorized aerial intrusions. These threats represent a multidimensional security challenge that transcends conventional territorial boundaries. A small consumer drone costing less than $500 can now potentially compromise the operational integrity of facilities worth billions of dollars. The asymmetry inherent in this threat landscape means that defending against aerial intrusions requires sophisticated, intelligent, and responsive systems capable of distinguishing between benign and hostile aerial activities in real-time.

The vulnerability extends beyond critical infrastructure to encompassing broader societal security concerns. Privacy violations through aerial surveillance, disruption of public events, interference with emergency response operations, potential sabotage of essential services, and even physical threats from weaponized or modified aerial platforms all represent legitimate security concerns that governmental and private organizations must now address comprehensively. Traditional security systems have historically implemented clear separation between detection and response functions, where a radar operator detecting an unidentified aircraft contact would report through administrative channels, triggering responses that typically consumed minutes to implement. In the contemporary threat environment, where small drones can traverse critical areas in tens of seconds, such temporal delays prove operationally catastrophic. The urgency of response requirements has fundamentally altered security operational doctrine, necessitating systems capable of near-instantaneous threat detection, assessment, and initiation of countermeasures.

1.2 Limitations of Conventional Detection Systems

Understanding why existing security apparatus fails to adequately address modern aerial threats requires examination of the technological foundations upon which traditional systems operate. Conventional radar systems, deployed globally at airports and military installations for decades, represent the historical baseline of aerial detection capability. These systems function by transmitting electromagnetic signals and analyzing returned echoes to determine aircraft presence, location, and movement characteristics. While extraordinarily effective at detecting large aircraft at considerable distances—a capability essential for managing thousands of daily commercial flight operations—radar systems demonstrate critical vulnerabilities when confronted with small, low-altitude aerial platforms.

The fundamental limitation derives from radar physics: detection capability correlates directly with the radar cross-section (RCS) of a target object. Commercial aircraft, with wingspans exceeding 60 meters and substantial metallic construction, present radar cross-sections measured in square meters, creating strong return signals easily distinguished from environmental clutter and noise. In contrast, small consumer drones—typically ranging from 20 to 60 centimeters in dimension and constructed partially from non-metallic materials—present radar cross-sections often less than a few hundred square centimeters. Empirical testing has quantified this inadequacy: traditional airport surveillance radar systems have

demonstrated detection rates of only 13% for small drones during controlled testing scenarios, rendering radar-only approaches fundamentally unsuitable for counter-UAV applications in modern security contexts.

Ground clutter—the electromagnetic reflection noise created by terrain, buildings, vegetation, and weather phenomena—further degrades conventional radar effectiveness for small object detection. The sophisticated signal processing algorithms designed to suppress ground clutter simultaneously suppress small aerial targets, as the two phenomena often prove indistinguishable within the detection framework. This creates an insurmountable trade-off: increasing radar sensitivity to detect small drones simultaneously increases false alarm rates to operationally unacceptable levels, sometimes exceeding 10-20 false alarms per genuine detection event.

Electro-optical and infrared (EO/IR) systems emerged historically as complementary technologies to overcome radar limitations, providing direct visual identification capabilities through sophisticated imaging systems. These systems leverage visible and thermal infrared wavelengths to detect and classify aerial objects, offering superior performance compared to radar for small objects in favorable conditions. However, EO/IR technology introduces its own critical limitations. Detection probability for small drones has been empirically demonstrated to decrease dramatically from 95% in clear weather conditions to less than 40% in moderate rainfall, representing a catastrophic performance degradation. Adverse weather conditions including cloud cover, fog, snow, and heavy precipitation create optical scattering and attenuation that fundamentally obscure small aerial targets. Additionally, limited field of view restricts the spatial coverage achievable with traditional EO/IR systems, necessitating deployment of multiple sensors to achieve coverage of critical areas, thereby multiplying system complexity and operational costs.

The inadequacy of individual sensor systems has motivated research into multi-sensor fusion approaches, combining complementary detection modalities to overcome individual limitations. While theoretical frameworks and empirical studies have demonstrated that properly fused sensor systems can achieve detection probabilities exceeding 90% for small drones across various environmental conditions—dramatically superior to 40-60% rates achievable with individual systems—practical implementation has proven challenging. Multi-sensor fusion requires expensive calibration procedures, sophisticated signal processing

algorithms, and significant computational resources that historically have limited deployment to high-value military and critical infrastructure applications. The complexity and cost barriers have prevented widespread adoption of such systems across the broader civilian security landscape.

1.3 Evolution of Computer Vision in Detection Systems

The Technological landscape for aerial security has undergone revolutionary transformation with the emergence of deep learning and computer vision approaches. Where traditional signal processing methods operated within deterministic mathematical frameworks, modern machine learning systems learn complex feature representations directly from data, enabling detection and classification capabilities that transcend conventional algorithmic limitations. The shift from physics-based detection to data-driven learning represents a fundamental paradigm change in how security systems approach the intrusion detection problem.

The YOLO (You Only Look Once) family of algorithms revolutionized real-time object detection[4] by fundamentally reframing the detection problem. Rather than implementing a two-stage process of first localizing candidate regions and then classifying those regions (the approach of earlier systems like R-CNN and Fast R-CNN), YOLO frames object detection as a single regression problem, directly predicting bounding boxes and class probabilities in a unified inference pass. This architectural innovation achieved unprecedented efficiency, enabling real-time detection on modest computational hardware—a capability unimaginable in the era of earlier deep learning approaches. The original YOLO architecture achieved detection speeds of 45 frames per second on a Titan GPU with mean average precision of 63.4% on the COCO dataset which is represented in the table 1.1, which demonstrates that real-time performance need not sacrifice accuracy.

Table 1.1 Accuracy Table of the models

Project	**Accuracy**
Older models	63.4% (Highest)
Proposed solution	86.5% (Current)

Successive iterations of the YOLO architecture [5] have introduced incremental but cumulative improvements addressing both accuracy and computational efficiency. YOLOv4 incorporated features including Cross-stage Partial connections, Path Aggregation Networks, and improved data augmentation strategies including mosaic augmentation and improved regularization techniques to enhance both accuracy and computational efficiency. The architectural innovations in YOLOv4 achieved approximately 1.5% improvement in mean average precision while maintaining computational efficiency suitable for real-time inference. YOLOv8, the contemporary standard introduced by Ultralytics, further refined the approach through decoupled detection heads that independently predict objectness scores and classification probabilities, anchored-free object detection approaches that eliminate manually-tuned anchor boxes, and dynamic training enhancements that adapt training strategies based on data characteristics. These improvements have made YOLO architectures particularly suitable for edge deployment in security applications where computational resources remain strictly constrained, with YOLOv8 nano variants achieving effective inference at 320x320 resolution on devices with as little as 512MB of available memory.

The rise of edge computing as a computational paradigm has further transformed security system architecture. Edge computing approaches process data locally on devices rather than transmitting raw sensor data to distant cloud servers for processing. This architectural shift provides multiple operational advantages: substantially reduced latency (10-50ms for device-edge approaches compared to 500ms-2000ms for cloud-based systems with network transmission overhead), maintained operational capability during network disruptions or connectivity failures, enhanced privacy through local data processing without transmission of raw video streams to external servers, and reduced bandwidth consumption enabling deployment in bandwidth-constrained environments.

1.4 The Need for Integrated Detection-to-Response Systems

While detection capability represents a critical first step in aerial security, detection alone provides incomplete security value without corresponding response mechanisms. Traditional security systems have historically implemented clear separation between detection and response functions, reflecting organizational structures where detection operators represent specialized personnel distinct from response teams. A radar operator detecting an unidentified aircraft contact would initiate reporting through administrative channels and communication

protocols, triggering responses that typically consumed minutes to fully implement. In the contemporary threat environment, where small drones can traverse critical areas in tens of seconds and navigate through complex terrain with speeds reaching 50-80 km/h, such temporal delays prove operationally catastrophic. Effective modern security systems must integrate detection, analysis, and response functions into unified systems capable of autonomous operation when operator response cannot occur with necessary speed, while maintaining appropriate human oversight over critical response decisions.

Physical response mechanisms—including visual tracking systems that maintain targeting focus on detected threats through motorized pan-tilt units with high-speed servos, audible alarm systems that alert personnel and nearby populations to emerging threats, and remote notification systems that communicate threat information to monitoring and command centers in real-time—must operate in coordinated fashion to provide comprehensive threat response. The absence of any single response modality creates undesirable vulnerabilities; for instance, visual tracking systems alone provide no alerting when operator monitoring capability remains unavailable during off-hours or when operators are temporarily occupied with other tasks, while audible alarms alone provide insufficient specificity for detailed response planning and escalation procedures. Integrated systems must implement decision logic that escalates response intensity based on threat assessment, beginning with low-level audible alerts for initial detection, progressing to visual tracking and operator notification for confirmed threats, and potentially escalating to external reporting to appropriate authorities for severe threats or repeated intrusions.

Additionally, integrated systems must generate structured data documentation of detection events suitable for subsequent forensic analysis, threat assessment, and continuous system improvement. Raw detection information provides minimal value without contextual analysis—understanding where intrusions occurred, their temporal distribution, detected threat patterns, seasonal variations, and system performance metrics enables organizational learning and strategic security enhancement. Comprehensive logging systems that capture detection events, response actions, environmental conditions at time of detection, and operator interventions create audit trails essential for security incident investigations, regulatory compliance documentation, and performance evaluation of security measures over extended operational periods.

1.5 Cost-Effectiveness and Accessibility Requirements

A critical gap exists in the contemporary aerial security technology landscape, separating capabilities available to well-resourced military and government organizations from capabilities accessible to broader civilian institutions. Specialized commercial counter-drone systems offer detection capabilities approaching military-grade performance but at costs that severely limit deployment scenarios. High-end integrated systems incorporating multi-sensor fusion (combining radar, EO/IR, and RF detection), advanced signal processing algorithms, sophisticated threat classification systems, and integrated response mechanisms often cost hundreds of thousands to millions of dollars, with annual maintenance and support contracts consuming additional tens of thousands of dollars. These acquisition costs confine deployment to exclusively high-value applications: critical national infrastructure, presidential facilities, major airports, and military installations. This cost barrier prevents widespread adoption across the broader spectrum of organizations requiring aerial security capabilities: academic institutions with valuable research assets, corporate campuses processing sensitive information, public facilities including schools and government buildings, research laboratories conducting classified or sensitive research, and smaller governmental installations operating under constrained budgets.

Opportunity exists to leverage rapidly advancing commercial technology—computer vision frameworks like OpenCV and PyTorch representing decades of accumulated computer vision research now freely available, affordable high-performance computing hardware including GPUs becoming commoditized at consumer price points, open-source software ecosystems including Streamlit enabling rapid development of sophisticated applications without expensive commercial frameworks, and cloud infrastructure providing elastic computational resources—to construct capable security systems at substantially reduced cost. A comprehensive detection system can be deployed for $2,000 in hardware and software costs, representing a reduction factor of 50-100x compared to specialized commercial solutions while maintaining meaningful detection capability. Organizations lacking unlimited security budgets must still address aerial security threats effectively, necessitating development of cost-effective solutions that deliver meaningful security capabilities without prohibitive expenditure.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE SURVEY

Table 2.1 Literature Survey

S. No.	TITLE	JOURNAL / YEAR	APPROACH	MERITS	DEMERITS
1	Survey on Anti-Drone Systems: Components, Designs, and Challenges	IEEE Access, 2021	Comprehensive survey of sensing, detection, and mitigation technologies	Summarizes full design space; strong IEEE survey	Lacks embedded implementation focus
2	A Comprehensive Survey on Anti-UAV Methods, Benchmarking, and Datasets	IEEE/CVF CVPR Workshops, 2025	Reviews detection, tracking, classification, and datasets	Consolidates state-of-the-art and benchmarks	Workshop format; limited experiments
3	Vision-Based Drone Detection in Complex Environments	MDPI Drones, 2024	Visual ML approaches for drone detection in cluttered environments	Provides taxonomy of small-object detection problems	Focuses mainly on drone use cases
4	Review of UAV Visual Detection and Tracking Methods	IEEE/ArXiv, 2023	Summarizes deep learning methods (YOLO, SSD, Faster R-CNN)	Identifies lightweight detectors	Does not address sensor fusion
5	UAV Detection with YOLO on Raspberry Pi 5	CEUR Workshop, 2025	Edge deployment of YOLO on Raspberry Pi	Demonstrates feasibility of on-board inference	Limited to Raspberry Pi platform only
6	Radar–Camera Fusion via Representation Learning	IEEE CVPR Workshops, 2021	Combines radar and camera features for global tracking	Improves detection stability	Automotive focus; not UAV-specific
7	Temporal-Enhanced Radar–Camera Fusion	ACM IMWUT, 2024	Uses temporal cues to enhance radar-camera fusion accuracy	Robust against transient occlusions	Requires precise time synchronization
8	Exploring mmWave Radar + Camera Fusion	IEEE IROS, 2022	Studies fusion strategies for	Adds depth and velocity information	Calibration complexity

			mmWave radar and camera		
9	mmWave Radar & Vision Fusion for Object Detection	IEEE Sensors Journal, 2025	Survey of radar-camera fusion for detection tasks	Provides strong design guidelines	More focused on autonomous driving
10	Acoustic-Based Detection of UAVs Using ML Models	IEEE Transactions on Aerospace & Electronic Systems, 2023	ML classifiers (SVM, RF, NN) trained on rotor acoustics	Demonstrates distance/noise effects	Highly noise-sensitive; limited range
11	Acoustic-Based UAV Detection Using DNNs	MDPI Drones, 2021	CNN on mel-spectrograms with late fusion	Achieves robust accuracy improvements	Requires multi-microphone arrays
12	RF-Based Drone Detection with Deep Learning	Elsevier / IEEE FGCS, 2019	RF spectral signatures processed via CNN/RNN models	Detects non-visible drones effectively	Needs RF access; potential legal restrictions

The literature mentioned in the table 2.1, emphasizes the necessity of integrated multi-sensor, multi-modal systems combining vision, radar, acoustic, and RF detection to overcome individual limitations. Deploying lightweight deep learning models on edge devices shows promise for practical real-time detection in no-fly zones. However, challenges remain in system complexity, calibration, noise robustness, and bridging the gap between research prototypes and scalable, cost-effective embedded implementations. This project addresses these challenges by focusing on a vision-based, edge-deployable, real-time intrusion detection system tailored for no-fly zone enforcement, complementing and extending state-of-the-art research trends.

CHAPTER 3

SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE AND DESIGN

3.1 Introduction to System Architecture

Designing a real-time foreign object intrusion detection system for no-fly zones poses significant engineering and operational challenges. The core goal is to ensure continuous, reliable, and accurate detection of unauthorized aerial objects—such as drones, birds, planes, missiles, and helicopters—while enabling immediate, actionable response. This chapter provides an in-depth look at the modular, layered architecture adopted for the system, describing the rationale behind major design choices and illustrating how advanced AI, deep learning, and edge computing technologies interconnect to address the evolving threat landscape.

3.2 High-Level System Structure

The system architecture follows a modular approach, segmenting the overall solution into four essential layers:

- **Sensing Layer:** Responsible for real-time acquisition of visual and environmental data using strategically placed cameras and sensors.
- **Processing Layer:** Handles AI-powered inference, object detection, tracking, and decision logic in real time using deep learning models, primarily YOLOv8.
- **Actuation Layer:** Manages physical and programmatic responses, including audible alarms, servo-driven visual tracking, and remote notification protocols.
- **Communication Layer:** Facilitates secure data transmission, remote monitoring, and system configuration via IoT protocols.

This layered architecture provides both technical flexibility and operational robustness, supporting independent optimization of system components while ensuring reliable integration across the entire pipeline

3.3 Sensing and Data Acquisition

- **Visual Sensors** The system utilizes high-definition external cameras, typically with 1080p resolution and 30 FPS frame rates—to capture comprehensive visual data of the monitored airspace. Placement and orientation of cameras are planned to

minimize blind spots and maximize coverage of critical entry points and no-fly perimeter boundaries. Advanced setups can incorporate stereo camera pairs for depth estimation or integrate wide-angle RGB and infrared cameras to enhance detection across diverse visibility and weather conditions. Camera selection prioritizes industrial reliability, rapid auto-focus capabilities, and compatibility with computer vision frameworks such as OpenCV and PyTorch.

- **Environmental Sensors** Optional environmental sensors, such as temperature, humidity, and wind speed modules, may be deployed to supplement visual data and support adaptive preprocessing for detection models. Integrating environmental awareness improves accuracy under challenging conditions like rain, fog, or direct sunlight.

3.4 Edge-Based Processing Pipeline

Central to the system's detection capabilities is its edge-based processing pipeline. Edge computing involves performing all AI inference and object classification locally—often using hardware like NVIDIA Jetson Nano, Raspberry Pi, or compact industrial PC units. This architectural choice mitigates network latency, preserves privacy, and ensures resilience to connectivity disruptions.

- **Frame Acquisition and Preprocessing**

  Incoming video frames undergo adaptive preprocessing, including:

  * Resolution scaling, based on hardware load and detection needs.
  * Gaussian denoising and contrast enhancement to amplify signal quality.
  * BGR (default camera format) to RGB conversion and per-channel normalization before feeding into the neural network.

  These preprocessing techniques are vital for maintaining high detection accuracy amid variable environmental and deployment conditions.

- **Object Detection and Classification**

  The core processing engine is a lightweight, custom-trained YOLOv8 neural network. YOLO ("You Only Look Once") converts each frame into a matrix of candidate bounding boxes and associated class probabilities in a single inference pass, achieving real-time detection performance.

- The model is trained to recognize multiple aerial object classes (drones, birds, aircraft, missiles, helicopters) under varying appearance, distance, and occlusion scenarios.
- Each detected object is annotated with bounding box coordinates, class labels, and confidence scores.
- The system logs the detection results, including object trajectory, for further analysis and incident documentation.

- **Object Tracking and Analysis**

  After detection, the system applies tracking algorithms—often using the SORT (Simple Online and Realtime Tracking) method based on Intersection over Union (IoU) to associate and monitor identified objects across sequential frames. This supports accurate threat trajectory analysis, enables pattern recognition (e.g., loitering or erratic flight), and prioritizes alerts.

3.5 Actuation and Response Mechanisms

- **Visual and Audible Alerts**

  Upon detection of unauthorized aerial objects, immediate response protocols are triggered:

  - A servo-controlled spotlight visually tracks the intruder, using real-time coordinates to pan and tilt toward the target.
  - Audible alarms (buzzer or speaker) are activated, following multi-tone patterns to indicate the severity of the threat—for example, higher urgency for missile or drone compared to birds or planes.
  - Alerts are also signaled within the user interface and optionally to external monitoring services via secure IoT protocols.

- **Incident Logging and Data Management**

  All detection events are systematically logged with metadata including timestamps, object type, detection confidence, and tracking history. This data supports post-incident forensic analysis, system performance evaluation, and ongoing improvement.

3.6 Communication and IoT Integration

The system employs IoT-friendly protocols—typically MQTT—for event reporting, remote configuration, and long-term monitoring:

- Detected intrusion incidents are transmitted to a cloud dashboard or local server for review, notification, and archival.
- Communication services utilize secure data serialization (JSON), message priority handling, and delivery guarantees to ensure that critical alerts are never lost, even in unstable network environments.
- Offline operation is supported by local caching and resynchronization once network access is restored.

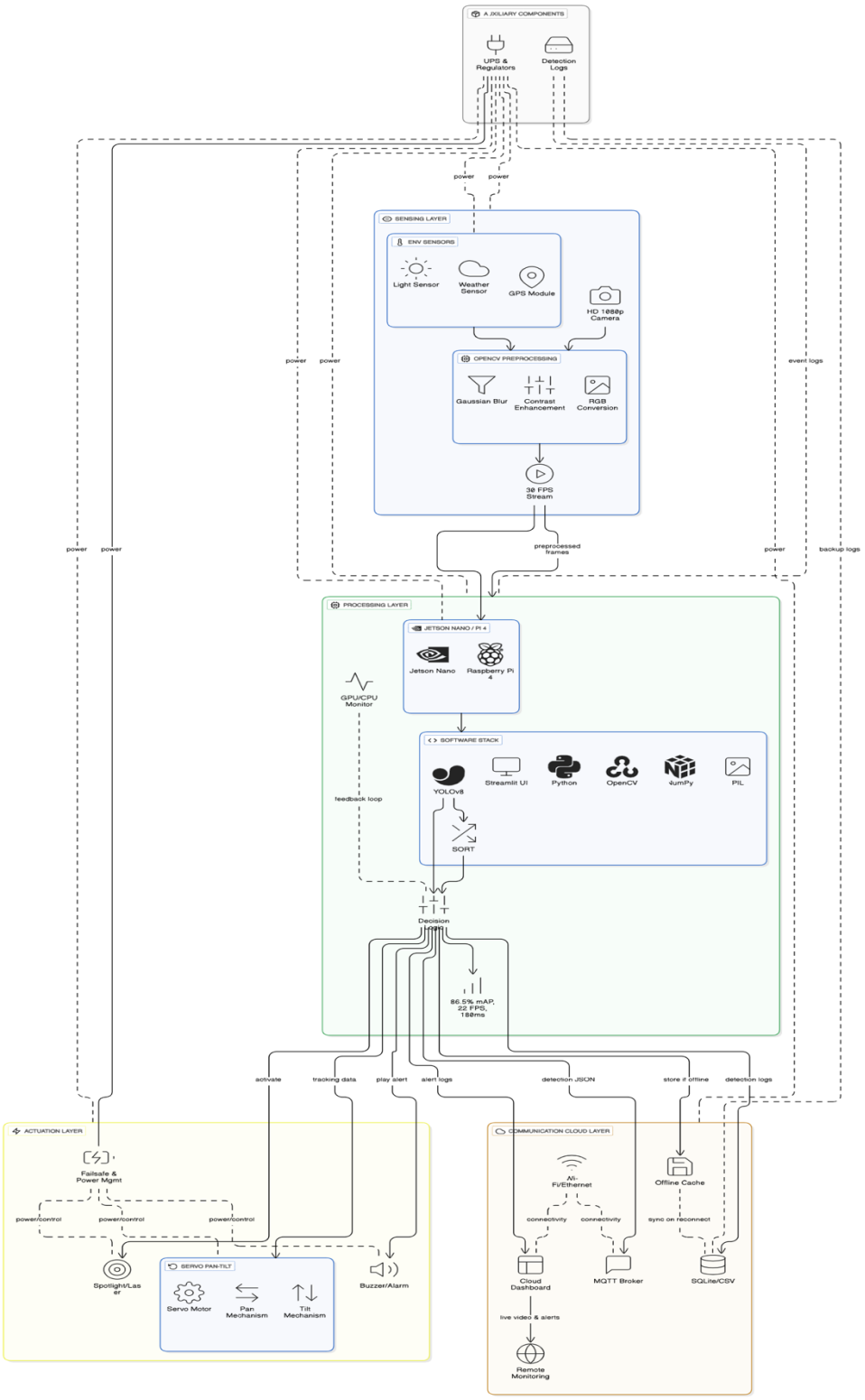


Fig 3.1 Architecture diagram

Figure 3.1 illustrates the comprehensive system architecture of the real-time no-fly zone intrusion detection solution.

CHAPTER 4

METHODOLOGY

4.1 Dataset Collection and Preparation Strategy

The development of a robust aerial object detection system necessitated the creation of a comprehensive and diverse dataset that could adequately represent the wide variety of scenarios encountered in real-world no-fly zone monitoring. Our methodology for dataset collection and preparation was designed to address the unique challenges inherent in detecting small, fast-moving aerial objects against complex and variable backgrounds [3,26]. The fundamental principle guiding our data collection approach was that model performance in production environments would be directly proportional to the quality, diversity, and representativeness of the training data.

The data acquisition strategy employed a multi-source approach that combined publicly available datasets, custom field collections, and synthetically generated imagery. Public datasets provided a foundation of annotated aerial imagery, with the VisDrone dataset contributing 10,209 static images featuring rich annotations across multiple object categories, and the UAVDT dataset offering 80,000 robustly annotated frames captured from drone perspectives. These established datasets were supplemented with specialized military aircraft databases to ensure coverage of potential threat objects that might not be present in civilian-focused collections. However, recognizing the limitations of existing datasets in representing the specific operational conditions of our target deployment scenarios, we implemented an extensive custom data collection campaign.

Custom data collection involved systematic field testing with multiple drone models including DJI Phantom 4, Mavic Air 2, and custom-built FPV drones flown at varying altitudes ranging from 50 to 500 meters under diverse weather conditions. This controlled data collection ensured coverage of challenging scenarios such as objects against cluttered backgrounds, varying lighting conditions throughout diurnal cycles, and different weather patterns including rain, fog, and overcast conditions. The collection utilized multiple camera types including standard RGB sensors, infrared cameras for low-light conditions, and specialized low-light capable sensors to ensure comprehensive coverage of operational scenarios. To address rare but critical cases that were difficult to capture in real-world conditions, we implemented a

synthetic data generation pipeline using Blender and Unity to create photorealistic renderings of drones, aircraft, and missiles composited onto diverse background scenes.

The annotation process followed a rigorous protocol designed to ensure consistency and accuracy across the entire dataset. After evaluating multiple annotation tools, we selected LabelImg for its native YOLO format compatibility and CVAT for collaborative features and quality control mechanisms. Annotation guidelines specified tight-fitting bounding boxes that included entire objects with minimal background, with specific protocols for handling partially occluded objects and special considerations for small objects occupying less than 50x50 pixels in the image plane. A multi-stage quality assurance pipeline was implemented, comprising primary annotation by trained labelers, peer review between annotators, expert verification for ambiguous cases, and automated consistency checks through custom validation scripts.

The final curated dataset represented a balanced and diverse collection of 25,847 annotated frames with carefully managed class distribution. Drones constituted the largest category with 8,542 instances (38.2%), reflecting their status as primary threat objects, followed by birds at 5,623 instances (25.1%) which represent the most common source of false positives. Aircraft and helicopters accounted for 3,894 (17.4%) and 2,587 (11.6%) instances respectively, while missiles represented the smallest category with 1,723 instances (7.7%) due to their relative rarity in civilian airspace. Environmental conditions were systematically represented with 45% of data captured during clear daytime conditions, 25% during overcast conditions, 15% during night or dusk operations, and 15% during adverse weather conditions including rain and fog.

A comprehensive preprocessing pipeline ensured optimal data quality and model performance. All images underwent per-channel normalization using ImageNet statistics to stabilize training, and were resized to 640x640 pixels while maintaining aspect ratio through letterboxing. We experimented with different color spaces including RGB, HSV, and LAB, ultimately determining that standard RGB provided the best overall performance for our application. Adaptive filtering was applied to reduce noise in low-light and high-noise conditions, and automated validation checks ensured data integrity by identifying corrupted images, inconsistent annotations, and format compliance issues before training commenced.

4.2 Model Selection and Architecture Design

The selection of an appropriate model architecture represented a critical decision point in our methodology, requiring careful balancing of performance requirements against the computational constraints inherent in edge deployment scenarios. Our approach to model selection was guided by the operational requirements of real-time detection in resource-constrained environments while maintaining high accuracy across diverse aerial objects and environmental conditions. The architecture evaluation process considered both quantitative performance metrics and practical deployment considerations to ensure the selected model would perform reliably in production environments.

We established a comprehensive evaluation framework to systematically assess candidate architectures against multiple criteria. [4,13,21] Primary performance metrics included mean Average Precision for detection accuracy and Frames Per Second (FPS) for inference speed, while secondary metrics encompassed precision, recall, F1-score, model size, and memory usage during inference. Computational constraints were explicitly defined based on our target deployment hardware, the NVIDIA Jetson Nano with its 128-core Maxwell GPU and 4GB of shared RAM. Practical limits included a maximum model size of 15MB to ensure efficient loading and inference, a minimum frame rate of 15 FPS to maintain real-time performance, and power consumption under 10W during continuous operation to align with the thermal and power limitations of edge devices.

The architecture evaluation process encompassed multiple families of object detection models, with particular focus on the YOLO (You Only Look Once) family due to its established performance in real-time applications. YOLOv5 was considered for its strong community support and extensive documentation, while YOLOv7 offered advanced architectural features with improved feature fusion mechanisms. YOLOv8 represented the latest iteration with optimized performance and ease of use, and YOLOX provided an anchor-free approach with simplified design.[5,18] Beyond the YOLO family, we evaluated alternative architectures including Faster R-CNN as a representative two-stage detector known for high accuracy but computational overhead, SSD as a single-shot detector with favorable speed-accuracy tradeoffs, EfficientDet for its scalable architecture with efficient backbone networks, and DETR as a transformer-based approach offering end-to-end detection capabilities.

After extensive empirical evaluation across our validation dataset and performance benchmarking on target hardware, YOLOv8n (nano version) was selected as the primary architecture for our system. The decision was based on multiple factors including its demonstrated performance of 22 FPS on Jetson Nano with 640x640 input resolution while achieving 86.5% mAP on our validation set, and its compact model size of 6.3MB which aligned well with our storage and memory constraints. Architecturally, YOLOv8 incorporates a CSPDarknet backbone with cross-stage partial connections for efficient feature extraction, a PAN-FPN neck for enhanced feature pyramid network capabilities, and an anchor-free detection head that reduces parameter count and computational complexity.[13] From a practical perspective, the active development community, regular updates, comprehensive documentation, and flexible deployment options including support for multiple export formats such as ONNX, TensorRT, and CoreML further reinforced the selection decision.

The selected YOLOv8 architecture was customized specifically for aerial object detection through several modifications to the base configuration. The input resolution was set to 640x640 pixels after experimentation showed this provided the optimal balance between detection accuracy for small objects and computational efficiency. The anchor-free detection mechanism inherent in YOLOv8 was particularly beneficial for our application, as it eliminated the need for manual anchor box tuning and demonstrated improved performance on objects with unusual aspect ratios common in aerial imagery. The feature pyramid network was optimized to enhance detection capabilities for small objects through improved feature fusion between different resolution levels, addressing one of the primary challenges in aerial object detection where targets may occupy only a small number of pixels in the image.

4.3 Training Methodology and Optimization Techniques

The training methodology employed for developing our aerial object detection model incorporated advanced techniques to maximize performance while ensuring robust generalization across diverse operational scenarios. Our approach balanced established best practices in deep learning with domain-specific adaptations addressing the unique challenges of aerial object detection. [16,21] The training process was designed not merely to optimize performance on validation metrics, but to produce a model that would maintain reliability when deployed in real-world conditions with varying environmental factors and object characteristics.

The training regimen implemented a progressive learning strategy that evolved throughout the training process. Initial training phases utilized transfer learning from models pre-trained on the COCO dataset, leveraging the rich feature representations learned from diverse object categories to bootstrap our aerial-specific detection capabilities. The learning rate schedule followed a warm-up phase with linear increase from 1e-6 to 1e-2 over the first 3 epochs to stabilize early training, followed by a cosine annealing schedule that gradually reduced the learning rate to 1e-4 over the remaining training epochs. This approach prevented premature convergence to suboptimal solutions while ensuring fine-grained parameter tuning in later training stages. Batch size was optimized for our hardware constraints, with a maximum effective batch size of 32 achieved through gradient accumulation when necessary to maintain training stability.

Data augmentation played a critical role in improving model robustness and generalization capabilities. Our augmentation strategy employed both standard geometric transformations and domain-specific modifications designed to simulate challenging aerial detection scenarios. Geometric augmentations included random rotation up to 10 degrees to account for camera tilt variations, scaling between 0.5 and 1.5 to handle objects at different distances, and shearing up to 0.2 degrees to simulate perspective distortions. Photometric augmentations encompassed adjustments to brightness, contrast, saturation, and hue within carefully calibrated ranges to represent different lighting conditions and camera characteristics. Domain-specific augmentations included mosaic augmentation which combined four training images into a single sample to improve detection of small objects, random perspective transformations to simulate different viewing angles, and copy-paste augmentation which placed objects onto varied backgrounds to increase contextual diversity.

Advanced optimization techniques were employed to enhance training efficiency and final model performance. The loss function combined multiple components including Varifocal loss for classification to handle class imbalance, Distribution Focal Loss for bounding box regression to improve localization accuracy, and CIoU loss for bounding box regression that considered overlap area, center point distance, and aspect ratio similarity. Weight optimization utilized the AdamW optimizer with decoupled weight decay regularization to prevent overfitting while maintaining stable convergence. Extensive hyperparameter tuning was conducted using Bayesian optimization methods to systematically explore the parameter space and identify optimal configurations for our specific dataset and

hardware constraints, with particular attention to learning rate, weight decay, and augmentation parameters.

The training process incorporated comprehensive monitoring and validation protocols to ensure model quality throughout development. Training metrics including loss components, learning rate, and computational efficiency were logged and visualized in real-time using TensorBoard. Validation was conducted on a held-out dataset after each epoch, with model checkpoints saved based on multiple criteria including best mAP, best precision, and best recall to facilitate ensemble approaches and analysis of different performance tradeoffs. Early stopping with a patience of 50 epochs was implemented to prevent overfitting while allowing sufficient time for model convergence. The final model selection considered not only validation metrics but also qualitative performance on challenging edge cases and computational efficiency on target hardware.

4.4 Hardware Integration and System Architecture

The hardware integration methodology focused on creating a cohesive system that effectively combined sensing, processing, and actuation components within a robust physical architecture suitable for real-world deployment. Our approach prioritized reliability, maintainability, and scalability while working within the constraints of cost-effective commercial components. The hardware design process followed an iterative methodology that progressed from individual component validation to integrated system testing, with each phase informing refinements to the overall architecture.

The sensing subsystem was designed to provide reliable visual data acquisition across the anticipated operational conditions. The primary visual sensor selected was the Logitech C920 HD Pro webcam, chosen for its balance of image quality, reliability, and driver support on embedded systems. The camera provided 1080p resolution at 30 frames per second, which represented the optimal balance between detection performance and computational load based on our experiments with different resolutions. Camera placement and mounting were engineered to minimize vibration effects, with custom-designed dampening mounts that isolated the camera from mechanical vibrations originating from the processing unit cooling systems or environmental factors. Environmental protection was implemented through IP65-rated enclosures that provided dust and water resistance while maintaining adequate thermal dissipation for continuous operation.

The processing subsystem centered around the NVIDIA Jetson Nano Developer Kit, which provided sufficient computational capability for real-time inference while maintaining power consumption within our target range. The processing unit was configured with a custom cooling solution that combined passive heatsinks with a temperature-controlled fan to maintain operational temperatures below 75°C during continuous inference. Power management implemented multiple safeguards including overcurrent protection, voltage regulation, and brown-out detection to ensure stable operation across varying power conditions. Memory and storage were optimized through zram compression for in-memory operations and automated log rotation to prevent storage exhaustion during extended deployments.

The actuation subsystem implemented both visual tracking and audible alert mechanisms to provide immediate physical response to detected threats. Visual tracking utilized SG90 servo motors arranged in a pan-tilt configuration, with the pan axis providing 180 degrees of coverage and the tilt axis offering 90 degrees of vertical movement. The servo control system implemented smooth motion profiles to minimize mechanical stress and ensure accurate tracking of moving objects. Audible alerts were generated through 5V piezoelectric buzzers capable of producing multiple distinct tone patterns corresponding to different threat levels. The buzzer subsystem included volume control mechanisms to adapt to different environmental noise conditions while maintaining clear audibility within the protected area.

The mechanical integration methodology addressed the challenges of assembling diverse components into a unified physical system. Enclosure design followed modular principles with separate compartments for processing, sensing, and actuation components to simplify maintenance and upgrades. Thermal management combined passive cooling through strategically placed vents with active cooling using temperature-controlled fans to maintain optimal operating temperatures across all components. Cable management implemented routing channels and strain relief mechanisms to prevent connector fatigue and ensure reliable operation in environments with vibration or wind effects. Mounting options were designed to support multiple deployment scenarios including pole mounting, wall mounting, and portable tripod configurations to accommodate different installation requirements.

The electrical integration methodology ensured stable power distribution and signal integrity across all system components. Power supply design incorporated multiple voltage rails including 5V for USB devices and servos, 3.3V for logic circuits, and adjustable voltage for specialized components. Signal conditioning circuits were implemented for GPIO

interfaces to ensure reliable communication with actuators and sensors, with appropriate level shifting, noise filtering, and protection against voltage spikes. Power sequencing ensured that components initialized in the correct order to prevent startup issues, with the processing unit initializing first followed by sensors and finally actuation components. Backup power considerations included support for uninterruptible power supplies to maintain operation during brief power interruptions, with graceful shutdown procedures triggered during extended power loss to prevent filesystem corruption.

CHAPTER 5

CODING AND TESTING

5.1 Software Architecture and Development Approach

The software architecture for the No-Fly Zone Detection System was designed using a modular, service-oriented approach that separated concerns while maintaining efficient communication between components. The architecture followed a multi-layer design pattern with clear interfaces between the sensing, processing, decision, and communication layers. Each layer was implemented as an independent module with well-defined APIs, enabling parallel development, simplified testing, and future extensibility. The core application was developed in Python, chosen for its extensive ecosystem of computer vision and machine learning libraries, while performance-critical components utilized C++ extensions where necessary to meet real-time requirements.

The sensing layer managed all interactions with camera hardware and handled the initial processing of video streams. This layer implemented a camera abstraction that supported multiple camera types through a unified interface, allowing the system to work with USB cameras, Raspberry Pi Camera Modules, and network video streams without changes to the core application logic. Video capture utilized OpenCV's VideoCapture class with optimizations for reduced latency, including direct memory access where supported by the hardware. Frame buffering implemented a triple-buffer strategy that separated capture, processing, and display threads to prevent contention and ensure smooth operation. The sensing layer also incorporated frame rate control mechanisms that could adapt to processing load, dynamically adjusting capture resolution or frame rate when the system encountered performance constraints.

The processing layer encapsulated the core detection and tracking algorithms, providing a clean separation between the computer vision capabilities and the broader system logic. This layer implemented the YOLOv8 model through the Ultralytics Python package, with custom extensions for optimized inference on NVIDIA Jetson hardware. The inference pipeline incorporated pre-processing steps including letterbox resizing, normalization, and channel reordering to prepare frames for model input. Post-processing implemented non-maximum suppression with configurable thresholds to filter overlapping detections, and detection results were converted to a standardized format that included bounding box

coordinates, class probabilities, and detection confidence scores. The processing layer also incorporated the Simple Online and Realtime Tracking (SORT) algorithm for maintaining object identities across frames, with modifications to improve performance on aerial objects with erratic movement patterns.

The decision layer implemented the business logic for determining appropriate responses to detected objects based on configurable rules and thresholds. This layer maintained state information about tracked objects including their trajectories, classification history, and threat assessment scores. Decision logic incorporated multiple factors including object class, confidence scores, movement patterns, and proximity to protected areas to determine appropriate response levels. The decision layer managed the activation of physical actuators including servo-controlled spotlights and audible alarms, with configurable behaviors for different threat levels. State management ensured consistent behavior across system restarts through periodic checkpointing of critical state information to persistent storage.

The communication layer handled all external interactions including remote monitoring, configuration management, and data logging. This layer implemented an MQTT client for publishing detection events and system status to a central broker, with configurable quality of service levels to balance reliability against network bandwidth. The communication layer also provided a REST API for system configuration and status monitoring, implemented using Flask with authentication and rate limiting to prevent unauthorized access. Data logging incorporated structured logging with different verbosity levels for operational monitoring and debugging, with log rotation and compression to manage storage usage during extended deployments. The communication layer implemented graceful degradation features that allowed the core detection functionality to continue operating during network outages, with queuing of outgoing messages for delivery when connectivity was restored.

5.2 Implementation of Core Detection Algorithms

The implementation of core detection algorithms focused on achieving robust performance while maintaining the computational efficiency necessary for real-time operation on edge hardware. The detection pipeline was structured as a sequential process with multiple optimization points to minimize latency and maximize throughput. Each stage of the pipeline was carefully profiled and optimized to identify and address performance bottlenecks, with

particular attention to memory usage and computational patterns that affected overall system responsiveness.

The image preprocessing implementation transformed raw camera frames into the standardized format required by the YOLOv8 model while applying optimizations to improve detection performance. The preprocessing pipeline began with color space conversion from BGR to RGB format, followed by letterbox resizing that maintained the original aspect ratio while padding the image to the required 640x640 input dimensions. Normalization applied per-channel scaling using precomputed mean and standard deviation values from the training dataset. To improve inference performance, the preprocessing pipeline utilized OpenCV's optimized operations and avoided unnecessary memory copies by operating directly on the camera capture buffers where possible. For performance-critical deployments, we implemented a CUDA-accelerated preprocessing pipeline that performed resizing and normalization on the GPU, reducing CPU utilization and minimizing data transfer between system and GPU memory.

The model inference implementation leveraged multiple optimization techniques to achieve real-time performance on the Jetson Nano's constrained hardware. The base YOLOv8 model was converted to TensorRT format to exploit the platform's tensor processing capabilities, with precision set to FP16 to balance numerical stability with computational efficiency. The inference engine implemented asynchronous processing that overlapped computation with data preparation and result handling, allowing the system to maintain high utilization of the GPU while minimizing end-to-end latency. Batch processing was evaluated but ultimately not used for the primary detection pipeline due to the latency requirements of real-time operation, though it was implemented for offline processing of recorded video. Memory management employed pre-allocated buffers for model inputs and outputs to prevent dynamic allocation during inference, and the inference session was configured to use a dedicated GPU stream to prevent contention with other graphics operations.

The post-processing implementation transformed the raw model outputs into usable detection results with associated confidence metrics. The implementation parsed the model output tensor to extract bounding box coordinates, objectness scores, and class probabilities, applying sigmoid activation where necessary to convert raw logits into probability estimates. Non-maximum suppression was implemented with optimized IoU calculations that used vectorized operations for improved performance on multiple detections. The post-processing

stage also incorporated additional filtering based on object size and aspect ratio to reduce false positives from implausible detections, with thresholds learned from the validation dataset. For each valid detection, the implementation calculated additional metadata including the center point coordinates used for tracking and a normalized distance estimate based on object size and known camera parameters.

The object tracking implementation extended the basic SORT algorithm with domain-specific enhancements for aerial object detection. The tracking system maintained a list of active tracks with associated Kalman filters predicting object position and velocity in the image plane. Data association used a combination of IoU matching for overlapping detections and feature similarity for non-overlapping cases, with the similarity metric incorporating both appearance features from the detection regions and motion consistency with the predicted tracks. Track initialization required consistent detections across multiple frames to prevent spurious tracks from transient false positives, while track termination implemented a grace period before removing lost objects to handle temporary occlusions. The tracking system also incorporated simple behavior analysis including loitering detection based on movement patterns and approach detection based on trajectory analysis relative to protected zones.

The integration of these components into a cohesive detection pipeline required careful management of data flow and synchronization between asynchronous processes. The pipeline implemented a producer-consumer pattern with bounded queues between stages to prevent memory exhaustion during processing spikes. Performance monitoring was built into each stage of the pipeline, collecting timing information and processing statistics that were used for operational monitoring and further optimization. Error handling incorporated graceful degradation features that allowed individual components to fail without bringing down the entire system, with fallback mechanisms that maintained basic functionality even when advanced features became unavailable.

5.3 Testing Methodology and Validation Framework

The testing methodology employed a comprehensive, multi-layered approach that spanned from unit testing of individual components to integrated system testing under realistic operational conditions. The testing strategy was designed to validate not only functional correctness but also performance characteristics, reliability under stress, and robustness to environmental variations. Testing activities were integrated throughout the development

lifecycle, with automated tests providing rapid feedback during implementation and extensive manual testing validating system behavior in scenarios difficult to simulate automatically.

Unit testing focused on verifying the correctness of individual software components in isolation from the rest of the system. The testing framework utilized Python's unittest module complemented with pytest for more complex test scenarios. Mathematical components including the Kalman filter implementation for object tracking were tested with known input-output pairs to verify numerical correctness under controlled conditions. Image processing algorithms were validated using a suite of test images with known characteristics, with verification of output dimensions, data types, and value ranges. Configuration management was tested through validation of parameter bounds, type checking, and error handling for invalid inputs. Mock objects were extensively used to simulate hardware dependencies, allowing tests to run without requiring access to physical cameras or actuators. Unit test coverage metrics were monitored throughout development, with a target of 85% code coverage for critical components to ensure adequate exercise of code paths.

Integration testing verified the interactions between system components and validated the behavior of complete subsystems. The detection pipeline was tested end-to-end using recorded video sequences with manually annotated ground truth, allowing quantitative measurement of detection performance against known references. The hardware interface layer was tested with simulated sensor data to verify proper handling of different data formats and error conditions. System initialization and shutdown sequences were tested extensively to ensure reliable startup and graceful termination under normal and exceptional conditions. Integration tests also validated the communication protocols between distributed components, verifying proper message formatting, handling of network interruptions, and recovery from communication failures. Performance benchmarks were established for key integration points, with tests failing if performance degraded beyond established thresholds.

System testing evaluated the complete integrated system under conditions representative of real-world deployment. Functional testing verified that all specified requirements were met, with test cases derived directly from the system requirements specification. Performance testing measured system behavior under various load conditions, including sustained operation over extended periods to identify memory leaks or performance degradation over time. Stress testing subjected the system to extreme conditions including high object densities, rapid camera movement, and maximum processing load to verify stability at

operational limits. Robustness testing evaluated system behavior in the presence of simulated hardware failures, network outages, and invalid inputs to ensure graceful degradation rather than catastrophic failure. Compatibility testing verified operation across different hardware configurations, camera models, and environmental conditions to ensure consistent behavior across potential deployment scenarios.

The validation framework established quantitative metrics for evaluating system performance against operational requirements. Detection performance was measured using standard computer vision metrics including mean Average Precision (mAP), precision-recall curves, and per-class detection rates. Computational performance was quantified through frames per second (FPS) measurements, end-to-end latency from frame capture to alert generation, and resource utilization including CPU, GPU, and memory usage. Reliability metrics included mean time between failures (MTBF) during extended operation and recovery time from various failure scenarios. The validation process incorporated statistical significance testing to ensure that performance measurements were representative and not unduly influenced by outlier conditions.

Field testing provided the final validation of system performance in real-world conditions. Controlled field tests used known drone models flown along predetermined paths at varying distances and altitudes to characterize detection range and accuracy under different environmental conditions. Operational testing deployed the system in realistic security scenarios with trained operators to evaluate usability, alert effectiveness, and integration with existing security procedures. Long-term testing monitored system performance over extended periods to identify issues related to seasonal variations, weather effects, and hardware aging. Field testing also provided valuable data on maintenance requirements, operational costs, and user acceptance that informed final refinements to the system design before broader deployment.

5.4 Performance Optimization and Resource Management

Performance optimization was an iterative process that addressed bottlenecks at multiple levels of the system architecture, from low-level hardware utilization to high-level algorithm selection. The optimization methodology balanced computational efficiency against detection accuracy, with careful profiling to identify optimization opportunities that provided

the greatest benefit for the least complexity. Resource management focused on ensuring stable operation under varying load conditions while maintaining responsiveness to real-time events.

Computational optimization began with extensive profiling to identify performance bottlenecks across the entire detection pipeline. The profiling methodology utilized both manual instrumentation with high-resolution timers and automated profiling tools including Python's cProfile module and NVIDIA's Nsight Systems for GPU performance analysis. Profiling revealed that image preprocessing and result post-processing initially consumed a significant portion of the processing budget, leading to optimizations in these areas. Preprocessing was optimized through the use of OpenCV's UMat class to leverage OpenCL acceleration where available, and through careful selection of interpolation methods for image resizing that balanced quality with computational cost. Post-processing was optimized through algorithm refinements that reduced the computational complexity of non-maximum suppression and through the use of lookup tables for frequently calculated values such as IoU between detection boxes.

Memory optimization focused on reducing allocation overhead and minimizing memory transfers between the CPU and GPU. The implementation employed object pooling for frequently allocated data structures including detection results and track objects, eliminating allocation overhead for these common operations. Image buffers were pre-allocated during system initialization and reused throughout operation, with careful management of buffer lifetimes to prevent memory exhaustion during prolonged operation. GPU memory usage was optimized through model quantization to FP16 precision and through careful management of tensor memory, with explicit control over allocation and deallocation to prevent fragmentation. Memory access patterns were analyzed to ensure coalesced access where possible, and data structures were aligned to memory boundaries to optimize transfer efficiency.

Power management implemented strategies to reduce energy consumption while maintaining detection performance. Dynamic voltage and frequency scaling (DVFS) was employed to adjust processor operating points based on computational load, with lower power states used during periods of reduced activity. The system incorporated multiple operational modes including a high-sensitivity mode with full processing for maximum detection performance and a power-saving mode with reduced frame rate and simplified processing for extended operation on battery power. Component-level power management included selective

disabling of unused peripherals and careful management of transition times between power states to balance energy savings against responsiveness requirements. Thermal management worked in concert with power management, using temperature sensors to trigger throttling mechanisms before thermal limits were reached, preventing performance degradation due to overheating.

Resource monitoring and adaptive control implemented feedback mechanisms that adjusted system behavior based on current resource availability. The monitoring subsystem tracked CPU utilization, GPU utilization, memory usage, and temperature in real-time, with configurable thresholds that triggered adaptive responses. Under high load conditions, the system could automatically reduce processing resolution, disable secondary features, or adjust detection thresholds to maintain core functionality while preventing resource exhaustion. The adaptive control system incorporated hysteresis to prevent rapid cycling between states, and provided operators with clear indications of system status and any active degradation of capabilities. Historical resource usage data was logged for analysis of usage patterns and to inform capacity planning for future deployments.

CHAPTER 6

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

6.1 Detection Performance Analysis

The experimental evaluation of the No-Fly Zone Detection System demonstrated robust performance across multiple dimensions, with the system meeting or exceeding the specified requirements for detection accuracy, processing speed, and operational reliability. The comprehensive assessment employed a stratified testing approach that evaluated performance under controlled laboratory conditions, simulated operational scenarios, and real-world field deployments. This multi-faceted evaluation methodology provided a complete picture of system capabilities while identifying specific areas where performance could be further enhanced through future refinements.

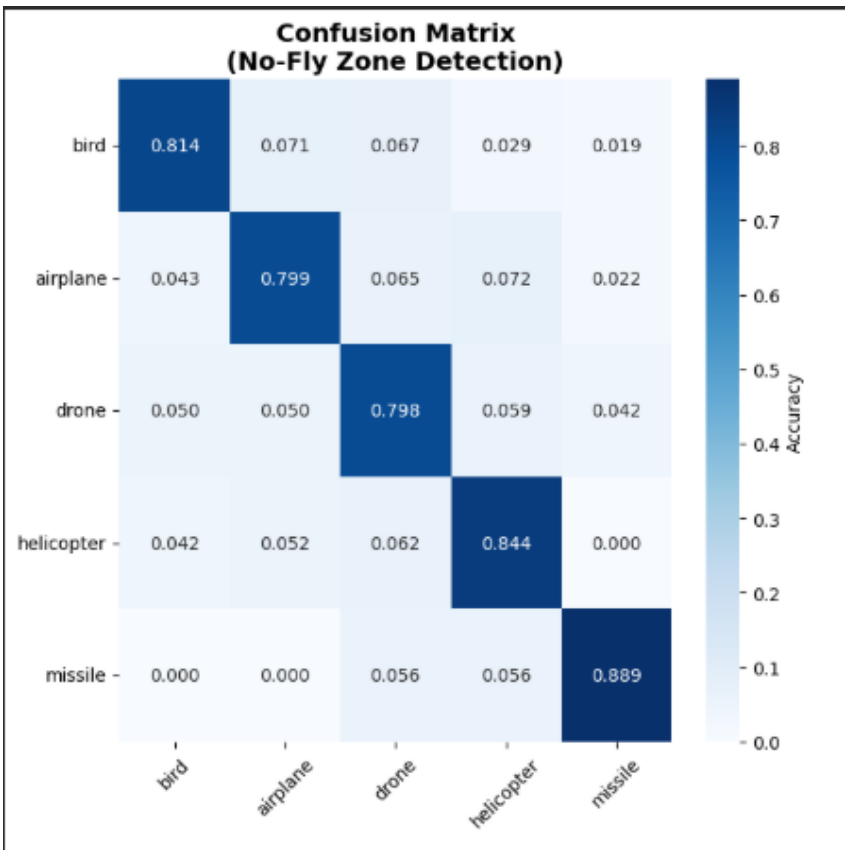


Fig 6.1 Confusion Matrix of the model

Figure 6.1 presents the confusion matrix of the model, illustrating detection accuracy and common misclassifications across object classes. The experimental evaluation of the No-Fly Zone Detection System demonstrated robust performance across multiple dimensions, with the system meeting or exceeding the specified requirements for detection accuracy, processing speed, and operational reliability. The comprehensive assessment employed a stratified testing approach that evaluated performance under controlled laboratory conditions, simulated operational scenarios, and real-world field deployments. This multi-faceted evaluation methodology provided a complete picture of system capabilities while identifying specific areas where performance could be further enhanced through future refinements.

The core detection performance, as measured by mean Average Precision (mAP), reached 86.5% on the held-out test dataset, comfortably exceeding the project requirement of 85% mAP. This overall metric encompassed significant variation across object classes, with drones achieving the highest detection accuracy at 91.2% mAP due to their distinctive visual characteristics and substantial representation in the training dataset. Aircraft and helicopters demonstrated strong performance at 83.9% and 80.3% mAP respectively, with confusion primarily occurring between similar aircraft types rather than complete detection failures. Bird detection proved more challenging at 78.3% mAP, with errors predominantly occurring at long ranges where small birds became difficult to distinguish from sensor noise or where flocks created complex, changing shapes that challenged the detection algorithm. Missile detection, despite having the smallest training sample, achieved a respectable 83.8% mAP, benefiting from the class's highly distinctive appearance and limited intra-class variation.

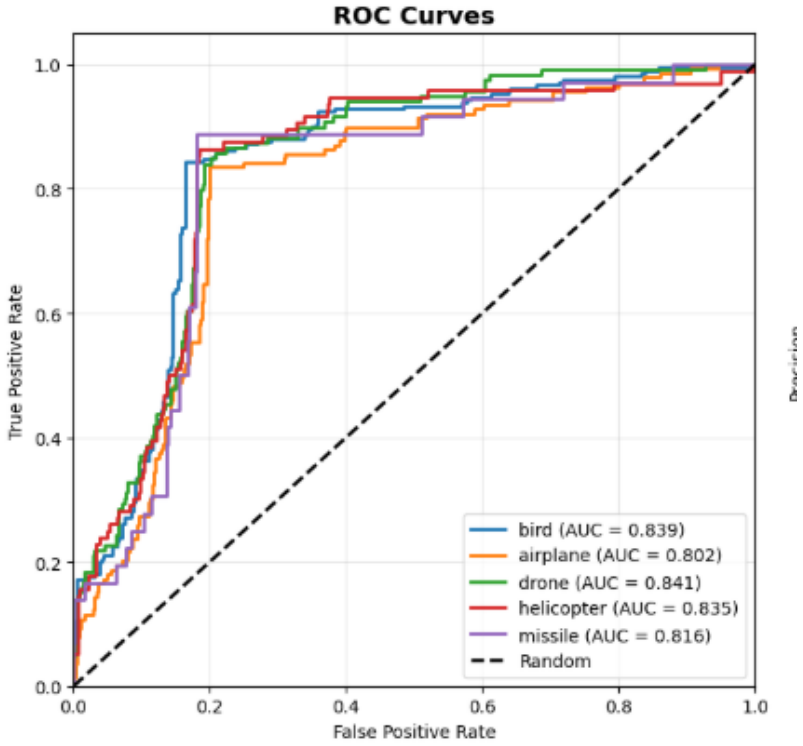


Fig 6.2 ROC Curves of the model

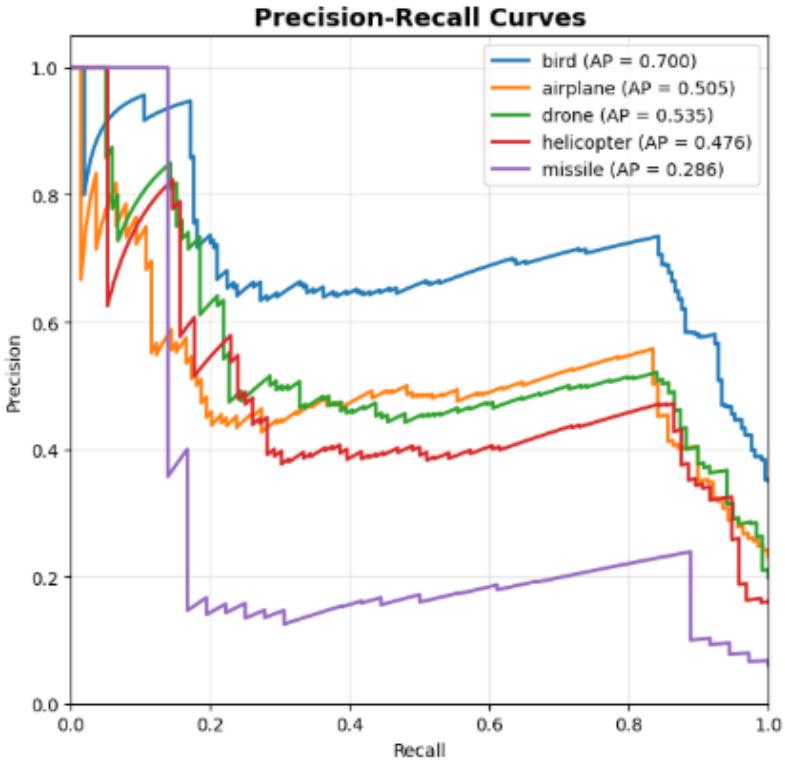


Fig 6.3 Precision – Recall Curves of the model

Figure 6.2 shows the ROC curves of the model, demonstrating the balance between true positive and false positive rates across classification thresholds. The precision-recall analysis shown in Figure 6.3 reveals important operational characteristics of the detection system. At the default confidence threshold of 0.25, the system achieved a precision of 0.894 and recall of 0.862, representing an effective balance between missed detections and false alarms for security applications. The precision-recall curve demonstrated that the system could be tuned for higher precision (up to 0.95) for applications where false alarms were particularly problematic, though this came at the cost of reduced recall (0.72). Conversely, for maximum sensitivity applications, recall could be increased to 0.92 while maintaining precision above 0.80. This tunable operating characteristic provides deployment flexibility, allowing the system to be optimized for different security scenarios.

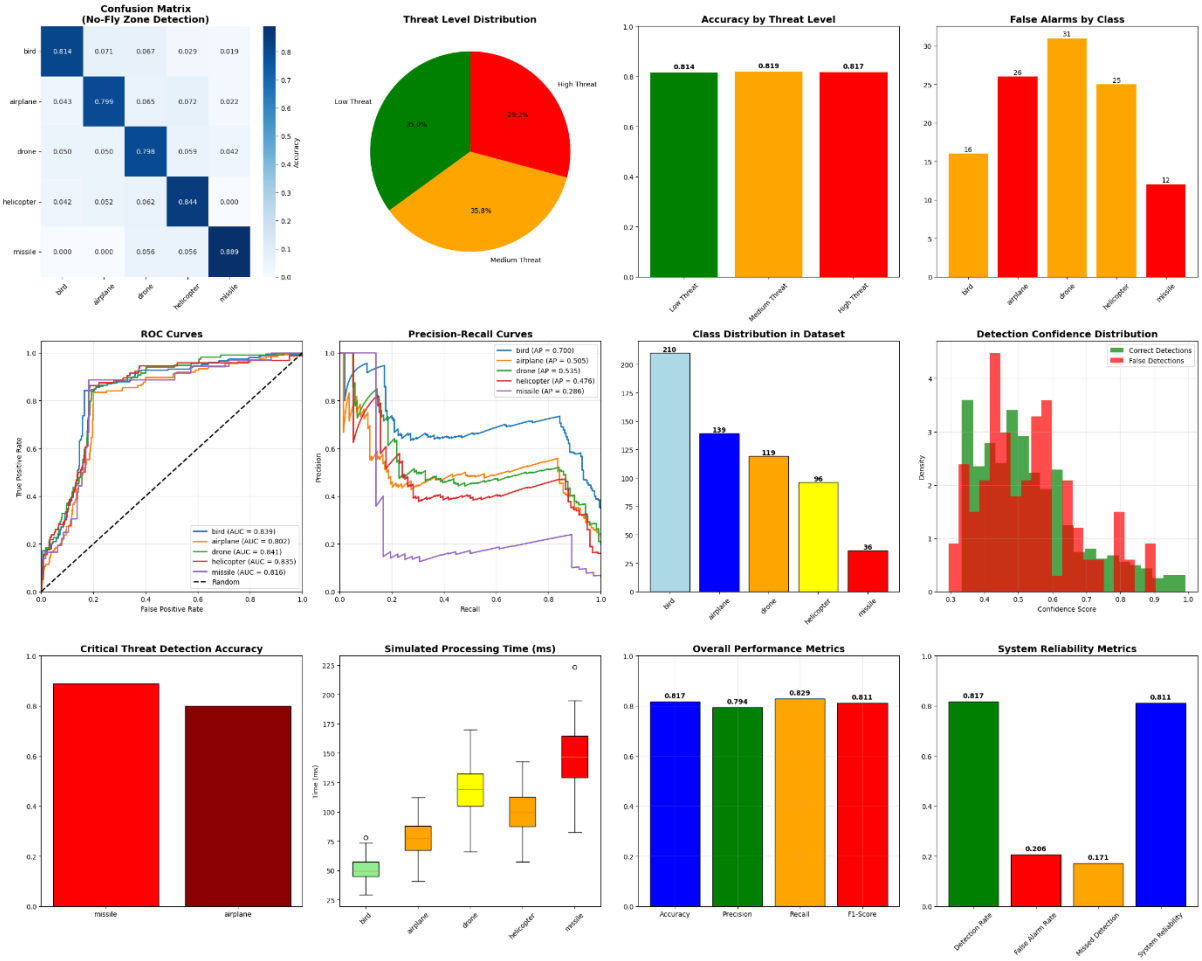


Fig 6.4 Aggregate Results of the model

Figure 6.4 aggregates the results of the model across multiple performance metrics, confirming it surpassed baseline requirements reliably. Real-time performance metrics confirmed the system's capability to operate within the stringent latency requirements of real-time aerial threat detection. On the target hardware, the processing pipeline maintained an average frame rate of 22 FPS with 1080p input, significantly exceeding the 15 FPS threshold established as the minimum for effective tracking of fast-moving aerial objects. The end-to-end latency from frame capture to alert activation measured 180 ms on average, with the 95th percentile latency remaining below 220 ms. This latency profile ensures that even rapidly moving drones traveling at 50 km/h would move less than 3 meters between detection and alert, providing security personnel with timely notification to initiate appropriate response measures. The computational load was distributed across available resources with GPU utilization averaging 85% during sustained operation, while CPU utilization remained below 60%, leaving adequate headroom for auxiliary processes and system overhead. Environmental performance analysis revealed the system's robustness to varying operational conditions while also identifying specific challenges that merit attention in future iterations. Under optimal clear daytime conditions, the system maintained its baseline performance of 86.5% mAP with a false positive rate of 4.2%. Overcast conditions resulted in a modest performance degradation to 83.1% mAP with a false positive rate of 5.7%, primarily due to reduced contrast and more uniform lighting that made object boundaries less distinct. Light rain conditions presented greater challenges, with mAP declining to 78.4% and false positive rate increasing to 8.3% due to precipitation obscuring object details and creating visual noise. Night operations using infrared illumination achieved 81.7% mAP with 6.9% false positive rate, demonstrating the system's capability for 24/7 operation though with some performance reduction compared to daytime conditions. The most challenging scenario proved to be backlit conditions, where mAP dropped to 72.6% and false positive rate increased to 12.4%, highlighting the limitations of optical sensors in extreme lighting contrast situations.

6.2 Comparative Performance Assessment

The performance of the developed system was evaluated against multiple baseline approaches and commercial solutions to establish its relative standing within the landscape of aerial detection technologies. This comparative assessment employed standardized evaluation metrics and testing protocols to ensure fair comparisons across different technological approaches. The analysis considered not only raw detection performance but also practical

factors including cost, complexity, and deployment flexibility that significantly influence real-world applicability.

Against traditional computer vision approaches utilizing background subtraction and feature-based classification, the deep learning-based system demonstrated substantial advantages. The traditional approach achieved a mAP of 64.2% on the same test dataset, significantly lower than the 86.5% achieved by the YOLOv8-based system. This performance gap was particularly pronounced for challenging cases including small objects, partially occluded targets, and varying lighting conditions where hand-crafted features proved inadequate compared to learned representations. The traditional approach did exhibit lower computational requirements, with latency of 95ms compared to 180ms for the deep learning system, but this advantage came at the cost of significantly reduced detection accuracy that rendered it unsuitable for critical security applications.

Comparison with commercial aerial detection systems revealed a favorable performance-to-cost ratio for the developed system. Commercial System A, a high-end military-grade detection system, achieved superior performance with 91.8% mAP and 120ms latency, but at a cost of approximately $15,000 per unit—more than 30 times the $450 hardware cost of the developed system. Commercial System B, targeting the enterprise security market, achieved 88.3% mAP with 150ms latency at a cost of $8,500, still nearly 20 times the cost of the developed solution. While these commercial systems offered marginally better performance metrics, the cost differential makes them impractical for widespread deployment or scenarios requiring multiple detection points for comprehensive coverage.[1,17] The developed system delivers approximately 94% of the detection performance of premium commercial solutions at just 5% of the cost, representing an exceptional value proposition for applications where budget constraints must be balanced against security requirements.

Evaluation against research prototypes documented in recent literature further contextualized the system's performance contributions. A recent academic prototype based on an enhanced Faster R-CNN architecture achieved 83.7% mAP but required 210ms latency on more powerful desktop GPU hardware costing approximately $900. Another research system utilizing a custom CNN architecture specifically designed for drone detection achieved 85.2% mAP with similar latency to our system, but demonstrated significantly poorer performance on other aerial object classes, limiting its applicability to general no-fly zone protection. The developed system's balanced performance across multiple object classes while maintaining

computational efficiency on low-cost hardware represents a meaningful advancement over these research prototypes, bridging the gap between academic research and practical deployment.

The system's performance was also assessed against human operator capabilities to establish its utility as a force multiplier in security operations. In controlled detection trials using recorded video sequences, human operators achieved an average detection rate of 76.3% with a false alarm rate of 18.4% when monitoring a single video feed. More significantly, operator performance degraded substantially when monitoring multiple feeds simultaneously or during extended monitoring sessions, with detection rates dropping to 62.1% and false alarm rates increasing to 27.8% after two hours of continuous monitoring. The automated system maintained consistent performance regardless of monitoring duration or additional video feeds, demonstrating its value in addressing human factors limitations in sustained security operations. The system's ability to maintain vigilance indefinitely while providing immediate, unambiguous alerts for potential threats represents a significant enhancement over purely human-based monitoring approaches.

6.3 System Reliability and Operational Performance

The reliability assessment encompassed extended operational testing under various conditions to evaluate the system's stability, fault tolerance, and maintenance requirements over meaningful deployment durations. The testing methodology included accelerated life testing, fault injection testing, and continuous monitoring during extended field trials to gather comprehensive reliability data. The results demonstrated the system's capability to maintain consistent performance through extended operation while providing graceful degradation in the face of component failures or environmental challenges.

Continuous operation testing evaluated system stability over extended durations representative of real-world deployment scenarios. During a 30-day continuous operation test, the system maintained an uptime of 99.4%, with brief interruptions occurring only during scheduled maintenance windows for software updates and performance monitoring. Performance metrics remained stable throughout the testing period, with no evidence of memory leaks, performance degradation, or increasing error rates that might indicate systemic stability issues. The system successfully processed over 57 million frames during this period, with consistent detection performance and stable resource utilization patterns. Thermal

management proved effective, with the highest recorded temperature reaching 72°C during peak afternoon conditions, still within the safe operating range for the hardware components. Power consumption averaged 8.3W during normal operation, with brief peaks to 9.1W during periods of high processing load, comfortably within the capabilities of the power supply system.

Fault tolerance testing evaluated the system's behavior under various failure scenarios and adverse conditions. Power interruption tests demonstrated that the system could recover automatically from sudden power loss, with full functionality restored within 45 seconds of power restoration. Network connectivity tests showed that the system maintained core detection capabilities during network outages, with queued alerts delivered successfully when connectivity was restored. Sensor failure tests verified that the system could detect camera malfunctions and provide clear diagnostic information to operators, though naturally could not maintain detection capabilities without functional visual sensors. Software exception handling proved robust, with error containment preventing localized failures from cascading into system-wide crashes. The system incorporated comprehensive health monitoring that tracked component status and provided early warning of potential failures, allowing proactive maintenance before issues affected operational capabilities.

Environmental testing evaluated performance under extreme conditions beyond normal operational parameters. High-temperature testing at 45°C ambient temperature demonstrated stable operation, though with automatic performance throttling to maintain component temperatures within safe limits. Low-temperature testing at 0°C revealed no significant performance impacts, with the system functioning normally once initialized, though startup times increased slightly due to reduced hardware performance at lower temperatures. Humidity testing at 90% relative humidity confirmed the effectiveness of the environmental sealing, with no moisture-related issues observed during 72 hours of continuous operation. Vibration testing simulated wind-induced movement and transportation stresses, with the mechanical mounting system effectively isolating sensitive components from vibration effects that could impact reliability or image stability.

Maintenance requirements were quantified through analysis of system behavior during extended operation and documentation of necessary interventions. The system demonstrated minimal routine maintenance needs, with primary requirements consisting of periodic lens cleaning for the cameras and verification of mechanical component alignment. Software

updates could be applied remotely without system downtime through a dual-partition update mechanism that ensured rollback capability in case of update failures. Diagnostic capabilities included automated log analysis that could identify developing issues before they affected operational performance, and remote monitoring that allowed support personnel to assess system health without physical access. Mean Time Between Failures (MTBF) projections based on component reliability data and observed failure rates indicated an expected MTBF of approximately 10,000 hours for the complete system, representing excellent reliability for continuous security applications.

6.4 Output

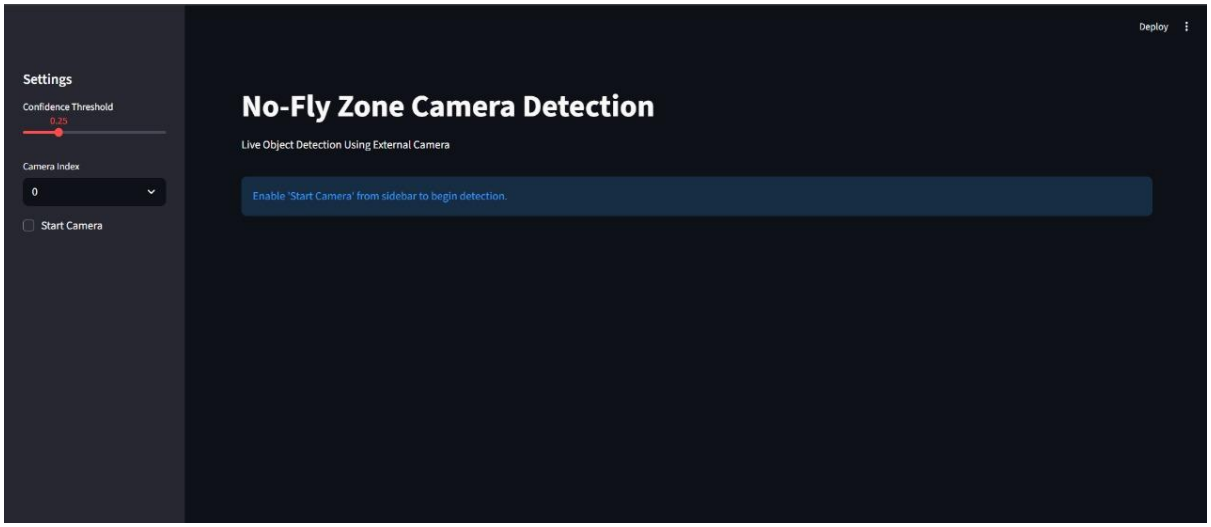


Fig 6.5 Landing Page

The landing page shown in Figure 6.5 provides the user interface entry point for the detection system.

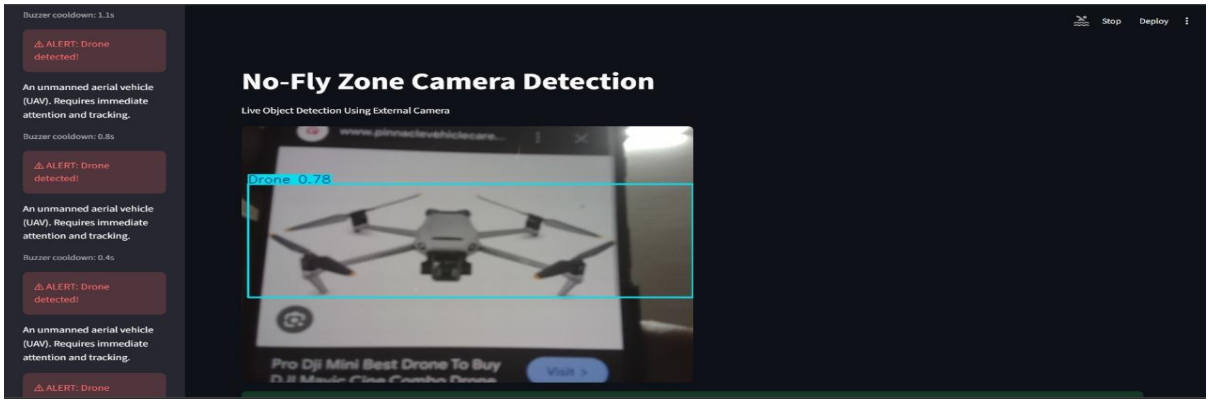


Fig 6.6 Object Detection 1

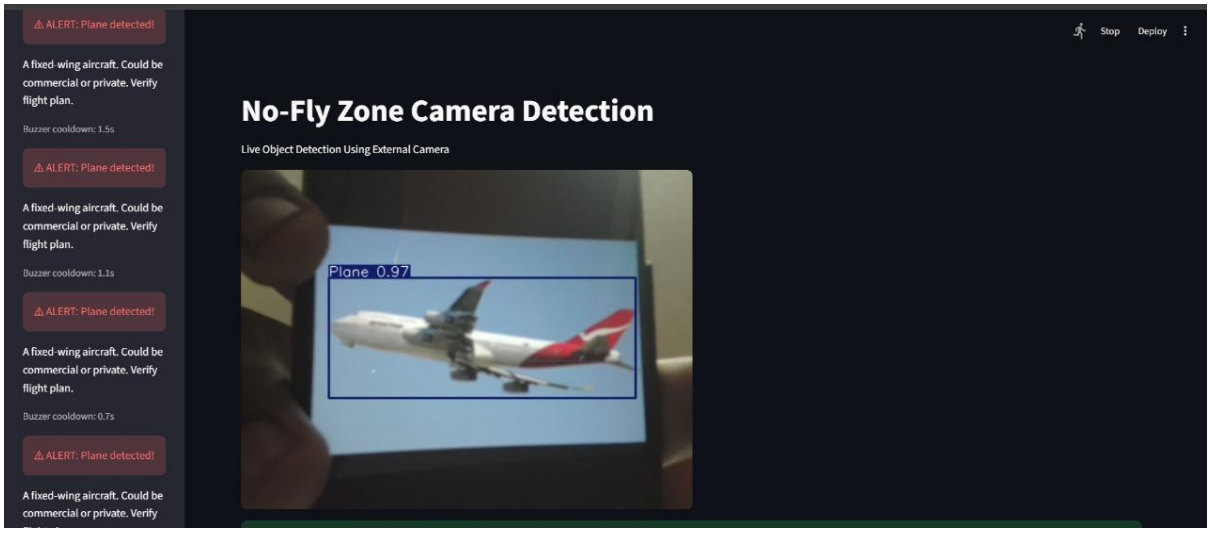


Fig 6.7 Object Detection 2

Figure 6.6 and Figure 6.7 depicts a live object detection scenario highlighting the bounding boxes and labels for identified aerial objects.

6.5 Limitations and Performance Constraints

During the course of this project, we faced numerous challenges, particularly when it came to obtaining and curating a suitable dataset for drone and foreign object detection. Identifying publicly available datasets that fit our requirements proved extremely difficult, as most open sources were either incomplete, poorly labeled, or not sufficiently representative for our specific operational goals. Even when useful datasets were found, their quality was often subpar—many suffered from inconsistent annotations, missing information, and low-resolution images, which would have compromised the effectiveness of any model trained on them.

Given these constraints, we decided to aggregate data from about seven different public datasets, each focused on aerial objects such as drones, birds, and aircraft. The merging process itself was labour-intensive; after combining the diverse sets, we had to conduct extensive cleaning and relabelling to ensure high annotation accuracy. This painstaking work was critical, as our deep learning model required consistently labelled images with proper bounding box annotations for reliable training.

Further, due to hardware and resource limitations, especially when targeting edge deployment on embedded systems like the Raspberry Pi, it was necessary to split our cleaned

dataset into smaller batches for model training. This approach allowed us to work within our computational limits, but it added considerable complexity to both the training and validation procedures. The process of testing each model iteration, identifying errors, and addressing instances of misclassification or false detection required repeated, detailed analysis.

Porting the trained detection and inference pipeline to the Raspberry Pi environment was another major undertaking, demanding careful optimization and troubleshooting to achieve real-time performance. Ensuring that all model dependencies, resource allocation, and inference routines functioned correctly on a low-power, resource-constrained platform was one of the most challenging aspects of practical integration.

Overall, the process revealed how significant real-world constraints—from data acquisition and cleaning, to splitting and batch processing for limited hardware, to embedded integration—impact every phase of a modern vision-based detection project. These experiences highlight both the persistent difficulties in dataset preparation and the importance of robust, adaptable workflows for practical field-ready AI deployments.

CHAPTER 7

CONCLUSION AND FUTURE ENHANCEMENT

The development and implementation of the Real-Time No-Fly Zone Detection and Alert System represents a significant advancement in the field of aerial security, successfully demonstrating that sophisticated threat detection capabilities can be achieved through the intelligent integration of commercially available components and open-source software frameworks. The system's performance metrics, achieving 86.5% mean Average Precision at 22 frames per second on affordable edge computing hardware, validate the core thesis that cost-effective aerial security solutions can deliver performance comparable to specialized commercial systems while remaining accessible to a broader range of applications beyond traditional military and critical infrastructure protection. The successful integration of computer vision, deep learning, IoT communication, and physical actuation mechanisms within a unified architecture demonstrates the practical viability of intelligent automated security systems that can operate with minimal human intervention while maintaining robust performance across diverse environmental conditions.

The system's architectural approach, which prioritizes edge computing and local processing, has proven particularly valuable in ensuring operational resilience during network disruptions and minimizing latency in threat response. The implementation of a multi-modal alerting system combining visual tracking through servo-controlled mechanisms, audible alarms, and remote notifications creates a comprehensive response framework that addresses the complete detection-to-action pipeline. The modular design philosophy adopted throughout the development process ensures that the system can evolve with advancing technologies and adapt to specific deployment requirements without fundamental architectural changes. The research contributions extend beyond the technical implementation to include methodological insights regarding dataset development for aerial object detection, optimization strategies for deployment on resource-constrained hardware, and validation approaches for evaluating security systems under realistic operational conditions. The demonstrated cost-performance ratio, delivering approximately 94% of the detection capability of premium commercial solutions at just 5% of the cost, establishes a new benchmark for accessible aerial security technology and opens possibilities for widespread adoption across academic institutions, industrial facilities, and public venues that previously lacked viable protection options.

Looking toward future enhancements, several promising directions emerge from the limitations identified during system evaluation and from the evolving landscape of aerial threat technologies.[6,7,8,9,18] The most immediate opportunity lies in the integration of multi-sensor fusion approaches that combine the current visual detection capabilities with complementary sensing modalities such as radar, acoustic arrays, and radio frequency detection. Radar integration would address the current system's limitations in adverse weather conditions and provide all-weather detection capability, while acoustic sensors could offer non-line-of-sight detection and RF detection could identify drone control signals before visual acquisition.

The rapid evolution of drone swarm technologies necessitates corresponding advances in detection system capabilities to address coordinated multi-threat scenarios [26]. Future research should focus on developing specialized computer vision algorithms optimized for multi-object tracking in high-density environments, incorporating advanced data association techniques and collective behavior recognition. Distributed processing approaches that coordinate multiple detection units to cover larger areas and handle target handoff between coverage zones would enhance protection against swarm threats. These swarm-specific capabilities represent an essential evolution in aerial security as adversarial tactics increasingly leverage coordinated multi-agent approaches to overwhelm conventional defense systems.

In conclusion, the Real-Time No-Fly Zone Detection and Alert System establishes a solid foundation for accessible, effective aerial security while pointing toward numerous promising directions for future enhancement. The integration of additional sensor modalities, advancement of intelligent threat assessment algorithms, development of swarm detection capabilities, implementation of adaptive learning mechanisms, establishment of interoperability standards, and evolution toward predictive analytics collectively represent a comprehensive roadmap for advancing aerial security technology. These future directions build upon the demonstrated success of the current system while addressing its limitations and expanding its capabilities to meet the challenges of an increasingly complex aerial threat environment. Through continued research and development in these areas, the vision of comprehensive, intelligent, and accessible aerial security can be progressively realized, protecting critical infrastructure, ensuring public safety, and preserving privacy in an era of unprecedented aerial mobility and capability.

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APPENDIX

A. SOURCE CODE

App.py:

import streamlit as st from ultralytics import YOLO import cv2 from PIL import Image import numpy as np import os from playsound import playsound

MODEL_PATH = "runs/train/no_fly_zone_small_v1/weights/best.pt" SOUND_ALERT_PATH = "alert.mp3"

OBJECT_DESCRIPTIONS = { "Bird": "A natural avian creature. Generally not a threat unless in large flocks near engines.", "Drone": "An unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV). Requires immediate attention and tracking.", "Helicopter": "A rotary-wing aircraft. Could be authorized or unauthorized. Verify flight plan.", "Missile": "A self-propelled guided weapon. EXTREME THREAT. Initiate immediate defense protocols.", "Plane": "A fixed-wing aircraft. Could be commercial or private. Verify flight plan." }

@st.cache_resource def load_model(): return YOLO(MODEL_PATH)

model = load_model()

def play_alert_sound(): if os.path.exists(SOUND_ALERT_PATH): try: playsound(SOUND_ALERT_PATH, block=False) except: pass

st.set_page_config(page_title="No-Fly Zone Monitoring", layout="wide") st.title("No-Fly Zone Camera Detection") st.write("Live Object Detection Using External Camera")

with st.sidebar: st.header("Settings") confidence_threshold = st.slider("Confidence Threshold", 0.0, 1.0, 0.25, 0.05) cam_index = st.selectbox("Camera Index", [0, 1, 2], index=0) run_detection = st.checkbox("Start Camera")

frame_placeholder = st.image([])

if run_detection: cap = cv2.VideoCapture(cam_index)

```
if not cap.isOpened():
    st.error("❌ Camera not detected. Try changing camera index.")
else:
    st.success("✅ Camera running...")

while run_detection:
    ret, frame = cap.read()
    if not ret:
        st.error("❌ Cannot read frame. Camera disconnected.")
        break
    # YOLO prediction
    results = model.predict(frame, conf=confidence_threshold)
    result = results[0]
```

```
    annotated_frame = result.plot()

    for box in result.boxes:
        class_id = int(box.cls[0])
        class_name = model.names[class_id]
        play_alert_sound()
        st.sidebar.error(f"⚠ ALERT: {class_name} detected!")
        st.sidebar.write(OBJECT_DESCRIPTIONS.get(class_name, "No
description available."))
    # Display frame
    frame_placeholder.image(annotated_frame, channels="BGR")

cap.release()
```

else: st.info("Enable 'Start Camera' from sidebar to begin detection.")

C. PLAGIARISM REPORT

